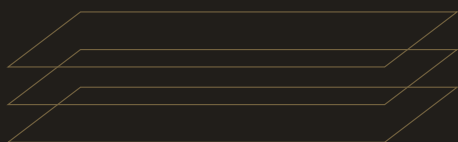


OPERATIONAL FRAMEWORK · APRIL 2026

An architecture for continuous compliance assurance

*Methodologies, Operations and the Measure of Integrity
Between Them*



Karim Bihi

The Price Reporting Standard

Independent analysis and research

“Compliance in price reporting is misunderstood at its foundation. It is treated as a matter of document control, revision and the establishing of audit trails. Although this is genuinely part of the work, compliance is in fact a process of managing the emergent behaviours that arise from the architecture that produces the price. In other words, it is the monitoring of the nodes of the system that generates a published assessment, the methodology, the governance structure, the operational decisions and the relationships between them. Emergent behaviour is behaviour of a system as a whole that arises from its parts interacting, yet is not present in, nor predictable from, any part taken on its own. In this context, that whole-system behaviour is the compliance state itself: it appears only in the interaction of the nodes, cannot be read from any one of them alone, and establishing it, reading it and managing it across every assessment is what this framework is built to do. To assess compliance is to trace that emergent behaviour back through the system, following the thread from the published price into the operation that produced it and into the documents that were meant to govern it.

Conventional internal audit strategies do not do this. They treat the system as if it were reducible, a closed equation, with the methodology as a known constant and the operation as a known variable, solvable from its parts. But emergent behaviour is precisely what cannot be solved for in this way. The operation contains behaviour the methodology cannot fully specify and the audit cannot see. Expert judgement gets masked. Application drifts. Causation goes unrecorded. The equation appears to balance because the missing terms have been treated as if they were not there.

The framework operates at the level those strategies miss. It begins where conventional audit ends, at the published assessment, and works back through the operation that produced it to the principles that assessment is meant to satisfy. The parts of such a system are coupled. A turn in the methodology moves the operation; a turn in governance moves them both; and the surface a firm presents to its auditor can be brought into perfect order while the planes beneath it stay misaligned. Each turn made to square that visible surface quietly rotates the ones no one is checking. Compliance is not how well any single plane is squared. It is the state in which all of them resolve at once, and stay resolved as the system keeps moving. The framework is built for that whole-system state, and for the price it produces, the marketable, assurance-backed assessment the principles exist to protect, rather than for the methodology document as one plane squared in isolation. It identifies and characterises methodology validity and application integrity as separate causal questions. It names the six patterns by which the two relate. And it reads pricing systems over time, surfacing the drift, the feedback chains and the trajectories that periodic engagement structurally cannot see.”

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Compliance is not a property of any single layer

Compliance within benchmark administration is not a property of any single layer of the system. It is emergent behaviour arising from how the layers interact, and the work of the compliance function is to position, track and steer that emergence rather than to audit any layer in isolation.

Two layers compose the system. The first operates at the document level — the methodology, the frameworks, the supporting compliance documentation. These describe what is supposed to happen and what the firm has committed to. They are the layer external assurance providers know how to examine, and the layer most internal audit programmes are built around.

The second layer is operational. The benchmark determination notes, the expert judgement, the market intelligence captured by analysts during assessment, the weighting calculations applied to specific submissions, the audit trails of every adjustment made. This is the layer at which the price is actually produced. It contains the reasoning that carries the contributor's data through to a published assessment, fortified with the compliance considerations that determine whether the price can be defended. The judgement that handles unusual market conditions is supported by documentation that exists precisely so the assessment can be defended if the firm is called to do so. That documentation also exists to give assessors the freedom and manoeuvrability to determine prices accurately under real market conditions, rather than constraining them into a process designed to satisfy the audit rather than the market.

The compliance function should be able to navigate the relationship between the two layers. In practice it rarely can, because the instruments available to it read only the first. An audit programme built to examine documents and sample records can confirm that the methodology says what it should and that the operational trail exists. It cannot establish whether the judgement recorded in that trail was sound, whether the reasoning behind an adjustment was complete, or whether the operation has drifted from the methodology it is presumed to follow. The behaviour that determines compliance happens in the second layer, and the second layer is what the conventional instrument is least equipped to read.

The framework set out in these pages reads the system at the level the conventional instrument misses. Drawn from operational experience inside an IOSCO-aligned PRA and from the audit lens that examines such operations from outside, it is built to surface three categories of structural finding that conventional audit programmes do not produce.

One. The methodology that is itself defective while the operation masks the defect through analyst competence — a compliance state that looks sound on every existing audit measure but collapses the moment the operational layer changes.

Two. The operation that has been quietly compensating for a methodology gap through analyst judgement the methodology does not authorise — the firm's compliance depending on individual capability rather than on the system the regulator believes is in place.

Three. The system that has absorbed structural change without the adaptive response that would correct it — a drift toward degraded compliance visible only across cycles, by which point the conventional engagement has signed its opinion and moved on.

Each is a structural compliance state observed in operational practice, not derived from theory, and each is designed to meet the evidence standards a formal assurance opinion requires. They are the kind of finding a regulator would expect a serious assurance programme to produce, and that no current programme produces at the cadence the system actually requires.



The published price is produced in the layer conventional assurance does not reach.

Two standards, two stacks, one shared substrate

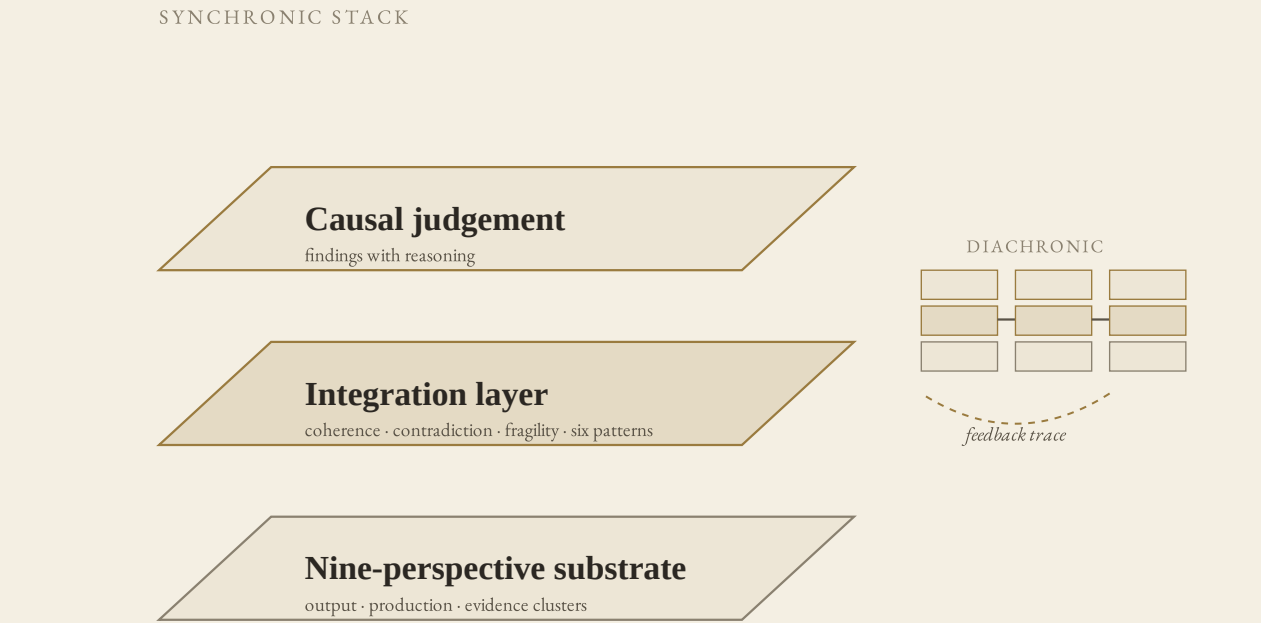
The framework reads compliance through two distinct standards operating on the same evidence, two architectural layers that share a substrate of nine perspectives across three clusters, and a continuous cycle that runs at the cadence of the benchmark itself.

The two standards answer two distinct questions that conventional assurance treats as one. The methodology validity standard asks whether the documentary architecture is itself compliant against the principles the regulatory regime requires. The adequate application standard, derived from the validated methodology, asks whether each assessment cycle has actually applied the methodology with the integrity its own specification demands. A firm whose methodology is principle-compliant but whose operation has drifted from it is non-compliant. A firm whose operation perfectly applies a methodology that does not satisfy the principles is also non-compliant. Conventional programmes conflate the two; the framework separates them deliberately, because the most diagnostically important findings appear in the relationship between them.

The architecture operates in two stacks that share a common substrate. The synchronic stack reads each assessment cycle at the moment of its production. The diachronic stack reads the system across cycles, producing findings about drift, feedback and trajectory that no single-cycle reading can produce. The shared substrate is the nine perspectives, grouped into three clusters that read the operation from different angles.

The perspectives operate in parallel rather than sequentially. A sequential reading collapses into a checklist; parallel reading preserves the independence of each perspective and lets the integration layer detect coherence, contradiction and fragility across them. The integration is what makes compliance findings emergent rather than additive — a finding produced by integrating across nine perspectives carries a different evidential weight from a finding produced by any single perspective alone.

THE FRAMEWORK · VISUALISED



The architecture in full. The synchronic stack produces findings per assessment cycle; the diachronic stack reads the system across cycles. Both operate on the shared nine-perspective substrate, integrated through the layer where the framework's distinctive findings emerge.

OUTPUT CLUSTER

What the benchmark produces — the published price and the principles it serves.

PRODUCTION CLUSTER

What produces the benchmark — methodology, systems, governance.

EVIDENCE CLUSTER

The operational trail by which production actually happened.

Is the methodology itself compliant?

Most compliance frameworks assume the methodology is valid and proceed to assess application. The assumption is not safe. A methodology can fail to satisfy the principles it is written to encode, fail to hold together across its supporting documentation, fail to be operationally viable when applied competently, or fail simply as a document. Each failure produces a different downstream consequence, and none is caught by the instinct to examine the operation against a methodology presumed sound.

Principle conformance asks whether each applicable principle is addressed by a provision specific enough to be operationally executable, and whether anything elsewhere in the corpus contradicts it. A principle is not addressed by being mentioned.

Internal coherence asks whether the documents hold together as a set — definitions consistent, cross-references resolving, process chaining with the governance that oversees it. A methodology that says *subject to committee approval* requires the corpus to establish that committee and define its procedure.

Operational viability asks whether the methodology can produce accurate output when applied competently. Are the inputs achievable, the discretion boundaries actually bounded, the deviation procedures executable on the timeline they specify? A methodology can be principle-compliant and internally coherent and still operationally non-viable.

Document integrity asks whether the corpus is in good order as artefacts — versioning consistent across documents that reference each other, effective dates recorded, the authoritative version identifiable to the operational layer that must apply it.

Four tests the methodology must pass

Principle conformance

Is each regulatory principle addressed by a provision specific enough to execute?

Principle 7 references a superseded document version

Material gap

Internal coherence

Do the documents hold together — definitions, cross-references, chained process?

Definitions consistent across the corpus; cross-reference to section 6.1 resolves

Coherent

Operational viability

Can the methodology produce accurate output when applied competently?

Variance approval required within one day; committee meets monthly

Inexecutable

Document integrity

Are the artefacts in order — versioned, dated, authoritative version identifiable?

Methodology references framework v4.0; the framework is at v4.1

Inconsistent

Each dimension is a test the documentary corpus must pass. A methodology that fails any one undermines everything the operation builds on it — and three of the four findings shown here would pass unnoticed in a conventional review.

Was the methodology applied with integrity?

A methodology that passes validity can still fail in application. The adequate application standard, derived from the validated methodology, evaluates each assessment cycle against the conditions the methodology required for the price to have been produced properly. It converts an abstract specification into a checkable set of requirements against the operational record. Five categories matter.

Threshold requirements set minimums and maximums — contributor counts, transaction volumes, permissible adjustments, liquidity floors. The cleanest to check because they are numeric.

Presence requirements specify that when an operational action occurs, the methodology-required documentation must exist alongside it. When they fail, the failure is not that the operation produced a wrong outcome — it is that the operation cannot evidence why the outcome was reached.

Conformance requirements bind operational judgement to the methodology's authorised range. Adjustments cannot exceed their caps; discretion must fall within the boundaries the methodology defines.

Process requirements govern how deviations are handled — the proper approval, the required notification within the documented window, the audit trail completed before the cycle closes.

Quality requirements set standards for documentation content and density. A judgement record cannot be a single line. Without them, presence requirements collapse into box-ticking — a record that exists but contains nothing diagnostic is the appearance of evidence, more dangerous than its absence.

One cycle, five requirements, four states

Threshold	Minimum three contributors	Met — four active
Presence	Expert judgement record above \$0.50	Met — record present
Conformance	Grade adjustment within authorised range	Met
Process	Significant move from prior assessment reviewed by a second analyst	Indeterminate — no review record
Quality	Market intelligence record density	Unmet — single sentence

Five categories evaluated against the operational record at each cycle. The indeterminate state — where the record is too thin to support a conclusion — is itself a finding, and often the most important one a continuous reading produces.

The diagnostic vocabulary

When the two standards are read together, six patterns emerge by which methodology and operation relate. Each names a structurally distinct compliance state, points at a specific remediation pathway, and carries different implications for the firm's regulatory and commercial position. These are what conventional audit cannot produce as standard output, because it reads each layer in isolation.

Both layers compliant. The methodology addresses the principle adequately and the operation applied it adequately. Compliance evidenced positively — which conventional assurance cannot do confidently. This lets a firm demonstrate its position proactively rather than relying on the absence of negative findings.

Application failure on a sound methodology. The methodology is fine; the operation diverged without documentation. Remediation is operational — training, supervisory control, capture practice.

Methodology defective, application masking it. The operation conforms to a methodology that does not satisfy the principle. The analysts have done their job. The gap is at the methodology layer, and the moment the operation changes the compliance collapses. The subtle pattern conventional audit does not catch — surfacing it lets a firm fix the issue while the operation still has the competence to mask it.

Compounding failures. Both methodology and operation fail. Serious but diagnostically straightforward; remediation required at both layers.

Compensating operation. The methodology has a gap the operation has been quietly compensating for through unauthorised analyst judgement. The price is fine, but compliance depends on individuals rather than the system. Remediation: formalise in the methodology what the operation is already doing well, before the operational layer changes.

Excellence above methodology. The operation produces outputs exceeding what the methodology requires. Not a failure, but signalling the methodology lags the operation's capacity — and an opportunity for the methodology to evolve.

Six diagnostic outcomes for one benchmark

PATTERN A

Both layers compliant

Transaction-based assessments on liquid days produce a price the methodology requires and the operation delivers. The audit trail evidences execution.

Remediation: none. Maintain practice and capture.

PATTERN B

Application failure

On three days contributor count fell below five and no market intelligence record was produced. Methodology clear; operation diverged undocumented.

Remediation: operational. Training, supervisory control.

PATTERN C

Methodology defective, masked

Methodology references a market intelligence requirement but does not specify what counts as adequate. Analysts produced detailed records anyway. Gap is upstream and invisible to audit.

Remediation: methodology revision before operation changes.

PATTERN D

Compounding failures

Variance approval required within one business day; committee meets monthly. Variance applied without record. Both layers fail at once.

Remediation: methodology and operational, simultaneously.

PATTERN E

Compensating operation

Analysts developed their own thin-liquidity practice — specific bilateral contacts, related contract pricing — documented but invisible to the methodology. Robust, but lost on personnel change.

Remediation: formalise current practice in methodology.

PATTERN F

Excellence above methodology

Records include alternatives considered and contemporaneous market structure beyond what the methodology requires, materially strengthening defensibility.

Remediation: evolve methodology to the new standard.

Reading the framework against a live price

The framework holds that a benchmark's compliance is a relationship to be read, not a property to be scored. IODEX, the Platts iron ore index, is where that claim can be tested on public ground, because everything needed to read it is disclosed. The reading rests only on published characteristics, so that any competent assessor would reach the same profile from the same evidence.

The propensity profile

IODEX assesses the spot seaborne market for medium-grade fines delivered CFR Qingdao, on a base of roughly 62 percent iron content on a 14 to 56 day laycan, struck each day at the 5:30pm Singapore close through the Market on Close process. The structural facts that define its propensity space are a matter of record. Platts collected on the order of one thousand spot seaborne transactions across a year, in the region of four observable trades a business day, while publishing some twenty-one thousand hears over the same period. Against that thin physical tail sits a financial complex of extraordinary scale: the cleared derivatives settled against the index trade close to six billion tonnes a year, several times the underlying seaborne physical market, at more than a billion dollars of notional a day, and nearly all physical term contracts and around seventy percent of physical spot trade on a floating basis referenced to the index.

The benchmark's systemic weight is therefore wildly out of proportion to the physical activity that produces it, and the methodology sets no fixed minimum number of transactions below which it will not publish. A normalisation layer compounds this: a cargo off the base specification is converted to it on an iron-unit basis, divided by its own iron content and multiplied by the standard, before value-in-use adjustments for alumina, silica and phosphorus. The published price is a constructed, normalised value. The design therefore makes a specific family of failures available: an assessment carried by very few prints, a price movable by a narrow set of participants, and a base specification that can drift from the market it represents.

The operational manifold

Against that space the operation answers principally through transparency. Every data point underlying the assessment is published for the market to see and challenge, and a daily rationale sets out the assessment logic. The volume and laycan guidelines fix the minimum size and timing of bids and offers so that what is published is meaningful rather than nominal. On thin days, value is anchored to the normalisation rules and the liquid derivative curve rather than published into a vacuum. This is an operation meeting a thin and consequential market not by imposing numeric input rules but by exposing every input to immediate public test.

The reading across dimensions

On transparency the constraint is severe and demonstrably met. Some twenty-one thousand published heards in a single year is near-total disclosure of how the price forms, and the operation has built durable practice around that exposure. On process and executability the same holds, through the volume, laycan and normalisation rules applied consistently. On these dimensions IODEX is not merely compliant but durable, tested daily by the market and held.

On two dimensions the reading is different, and here the framework earns its place. Input depth is permissive by design; four prints a day cannot be made to bear billions of tonnes of settlement by any operational effort, so on this dimension compliance is genuine but contingent, sound while spot is active and exposed the moment it thins. And the fit between the base specification and the physical market is the dimension on which IODEX's compliance has been most contingent of all, which is no longer hypothetical, because it has just been tested in public. Through 2024 and 2025, BHP and Rio Tinto lowered the quality specifications of their flagship brands. The deliverable market drifted below the 62 percent iron anchor on which IODEX and its entire derivative complex were built; brands below specification traded at a discount, while those holding quality traded at parity or a premium.

Read one cycle at a time, nothing failed. The methodology was applied faithfully every day, the normalisation machinery did precisely what it was designed to do, and a conformance assessment would have returned compliant throughout. But that is exactly the reading the framework argues is insufficient. Read as a relationship over time, the fixed anchor and a physical market of declining grade were drifting apart, an open chain in the framework's terms, with the normalisation layer quietly absorbing the gap. The drift attributes to the methodology dimension, not the operation: the operation was doing its job, and the base specification was the thing falling out of step with the market. That drift has now forced a structural correction. With effect from the 2026 derivative dates, Platts has migrated the settlement basis from 62 to 61 percent iron and introduced a 61 percent equivalent to carry the market across.

The structural finding

IODEX's compliance has a shape. It is durable on transparency and process, where the structure constrains severely and the operation has risen to it, and contingent on input depth and on the fit between specification and market, where the structure is permissive or the dependence is structural. The migration from 62 to 61 percent is the proof that the contingent dimension was real: a benchmark can be scored compliant at every single cycle and still be drifting toward a forced structural change that only a reading of the relationship over time would surface before it arrives. This is also precisely where the market has directed its scrutiny, never at transparency, which is near total, but at a thin, producer-concentrated physical basis bearing a financial complex many times its size, the contingent dimensions the framework had already located. Conformance scoring returns a single verdict and cannot express this. The framework returns the profile: where the benchmark holds, and where its compliance remains conditional on circumstances the operation does not control.

A finding is an argument, not an assertion

A finding without structure is an assertion. A finding with structure is an argument. The framework produces every finding with a four-part reasoning structure, because the difference between a dismissible finding and a defensible one is whether each link can be examined and verified.

What evidence the finding rests on. The specific records, entries or absences that constitute the substrate. Always traceable to source artefacts, directly observable, reproducible by anyone with access to the same evidence.

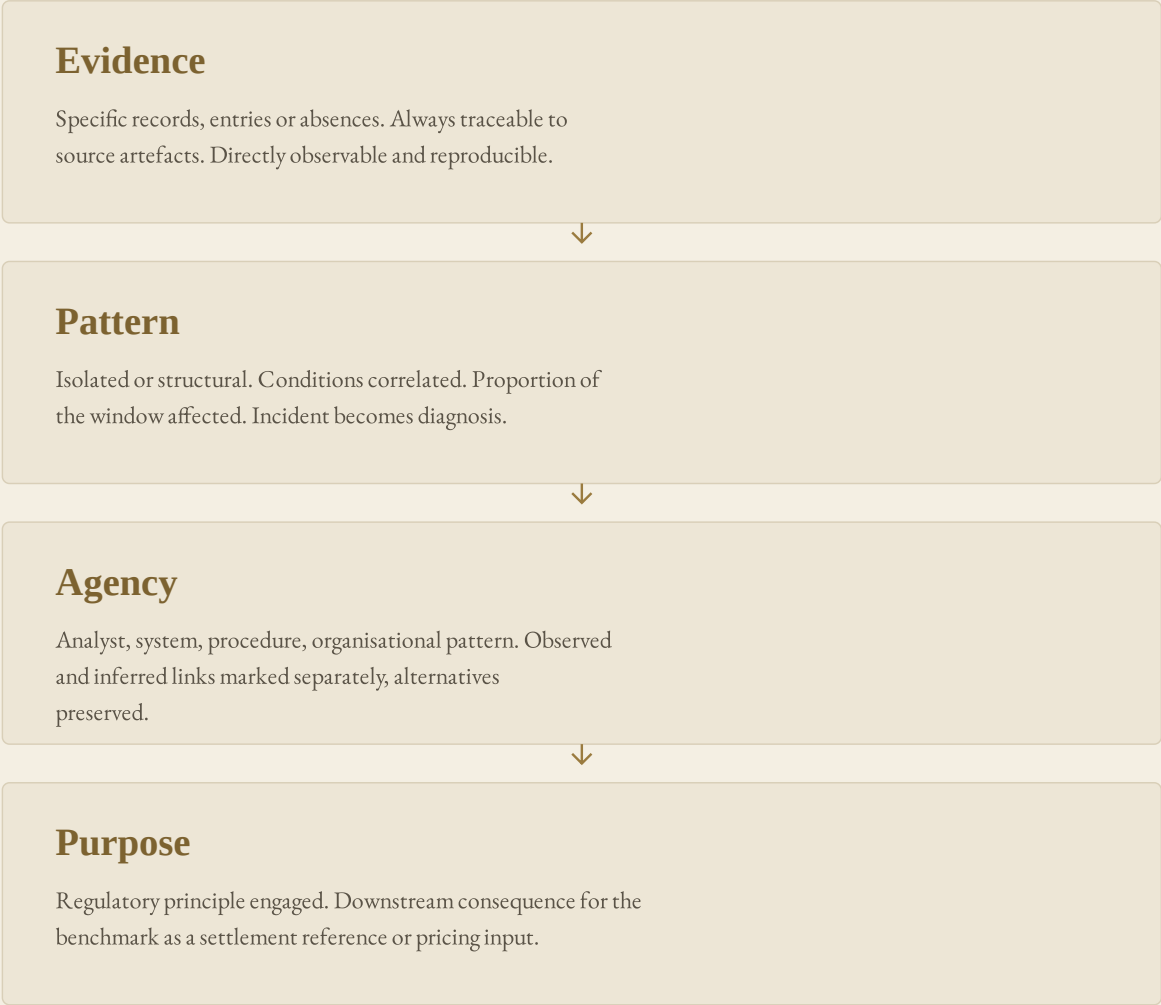
What pattern the finding takes. Isolated or structural, what conditions correlate with it, what proportion of the window it affects. This converts an incident into a structural diagnosis.

What agency produces it. Which analyst, system, procedural choice or organisational pattern. The most epistemically delicate part, because attribution often rests on inference. The framework is explicit about which links are observed and which inferred, with alternatives preserved. This honesty is what makes the finding defensible to a regulator's evidence standards, not what weakens it.

What purpose is served or violated. Which regulatory principle the finding engages, what consequence flows for the benchmark as a settlement reference or pricing input.

A finding with all four parts cannot be dismissed as anecdotal. It also speaks to every level of the organisation without translation — the analyst reads the evidence, the operational manager reads the pattern, compliance leadership reads the agency, the board and the regulator read the purpose.

ANATOMY OF A FINDING



Each finding traced from evidence through pattern and agency to regulatory consequence. Each link verifiable on its own terms; each inference marked explicitly with alternatives preserved.

A finding is complete only when its fate is recorded

The four parts of a finding establish what is true. A fifth establishes what was done about it. The framework records the disposition of every finding alongside its evidence, pattern, agency and purpose, because a continuous instrument that accumulates findings without recording their resolution builds a liability rather than an assurance.

What becomes of the finding. A finding is not complete when it is stated, only when its fate is recorded. Each carries its disposition: whether it is open, accepted, remediated, or consciously borne as a risk, by whose authority, and against what timeline. This is the part conventional incident logs omit, and the omission is consequential, because a finding recorded without its disposition is a naked statement of weakness sitting undated and unanswered in a record a regulator or a court may one day read. Disposition converts the body of findings from an accumulating ledger of unanswered deficiencies into a managed account of what was found, what was done, and what was deliberately and accountably left undone.

A finding carrying all five parts cannot be dismissed as anecdotal, and it speaks to every level of the organisation without translation: the analyst reads the evidence, the operational manager reads the pattern, compliance leadership reads the agency, the board and the regulator read the purpose, and leadership acts on the disposition. The same five-part structure carries to the diachronic findings, the drift and feedback chains that only a continuous reading produces, so that a finding made across cycles is held to the same standard of evidence and resolution as one made within a single cycle.

Compliance is made across cycles, not within one

Each assessment cycle is read at the moment of its production. But a benchmark administrator's compliance position is made over time — through the accumulation of cycles into trajectories, the propagation of upstream events into downstream consequences, and the drift of operational practice in directions not visible until many cycles later. Three operations convert a sequence of single-cycle findings into structural intelligence.

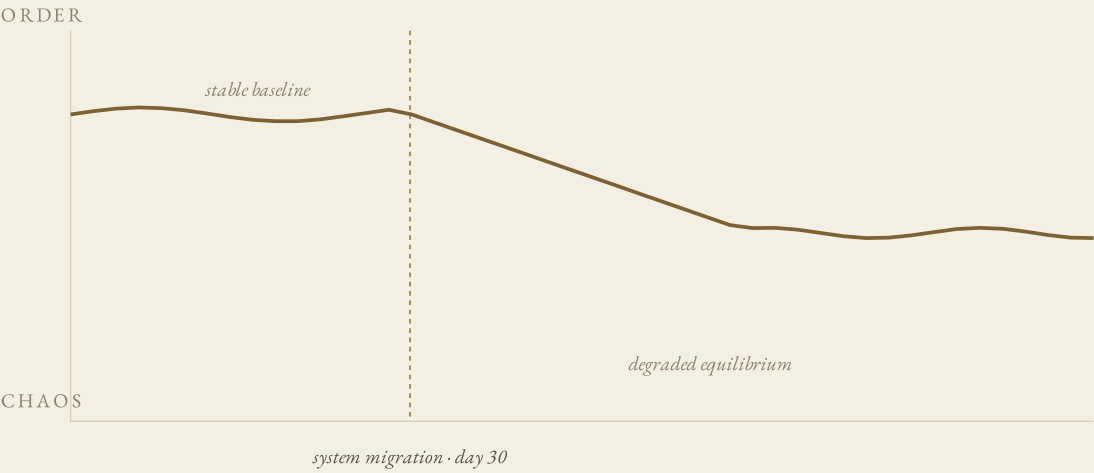
Differential analysis compares each new cycle against the previous and records what changed — records appearing, findings emerging or resolving, requirements activating as conditions shift. It produces no findings of its own but is the substrate the other two operations consume.

Feedback trace identifies multi-step causal chains across cycles. When a finding appears, the trace looks backward for its cause; when a methodology change is detected, forward for its consequences; when a price-level deviation exceeds threshold, backward to what in the substrate produced the move. Closed loops indicate an adaptive system correcting itself. Open chains indicate a system absorbing change without response — and a firm whose chains stay open across cycles is degrading regardless of how individual cycles appear.

Drift measurement records the direction the system is moving over a window — toward order, toward chaos, stable, oscillating. Drift is attributed to the perspectives driving it, distinguishing operational drift, where the record degrades, from methodology drift, where the corpus moves away from principle compliance. The attribution is what makes drift actionable rather than only diagnostic.

Diachronic findings carry the same four-part reasoning structure. They are findings only a continuous system can produce, because the patterns appear only in the comparison. This is what makes continuous compliance assurance a different product from periodic audit, not a faster version of it.

THE SYSTEM IN MOTION



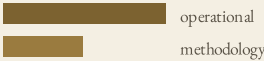
Differential

records added / removed
findings emerged / resolved

Feedback trace



Drift attribution



A ninety-day drift trajectory with the operational events that produced it annotated. The open chain in the feedback trace indicates a system absorbing change without correcting; the attribution shows the operational record is the dimension driving the drift.

Two preconditions, stated honestly

The framework operates on two preconditions at the benchmark administrator. The first is capture capacity. The second is configuration depth. Both are addressable, and the framework is honest about each because misrepresenting the dependencies would produce findings the firm cannot trust.

Capture capacity. The operational record must be captured at contribution-level granularity. If the record only shows that an assessment was published on a given date, the framework can check almost nothing. If it shows how many contributions were received, which were excluded and why, what adjustments were applied with what reasoning, what market intelligence was consulted with what content, the framework can do everything described in these pages. Most firms sit between these poles. The first valuable output for a firm whose capture is uneven is an honest assessment of what would need to be captured for continuous assurance to be possible — itself the gap analysis no current product produces at this depth, and the right basis for a maturity engagement rather than a one-shot purchase.

Configuration depth. The framework is configured per benchmark. Each cluster of perspective must know what evidence counts for this benchmark, what vocabulary resolves its terms, what quality criteria apply, what thresholds activate which requirements under which conditions. This is not generic compliance work. It requires knowing what an inadequate input set looks like for this benchmark in particular, what good market intelligence trails look like in this market, what the characteristic patterns of weak documented judgement are. Methodology depth at this level takes years to build, and it is what distinguishes a framework that produces credible findings from one that produces noise. The configuration is the work, and the work depends on the depth.

These preconditions are not barriers to entry. They are the honest statement of what the framework requires to deliver what it claims. A firm recognising that its capture is uneven, or its methodology depth concentrated in a few senior analysts, has not been told the framework does not apply. It has been told where the work begins.

Where a firm sits determines the path



Capture capacity and configuration depth together determine what the framework can produce. A firm in any quadrant has a viable engagement path; the path depends on where it currently sits.

Not a product. An engagement.

The framework is not a software product. It is configured, operated and maintained as an ongoing engagement, because the methodology depth that makes it work cannot be shipped, and because the regulatory regime, the market structure and the methodology itself continue to evolve. A firm running purchased software alone would produce findings without the configuration depth to trust them, which is worse than not running the framework at all.

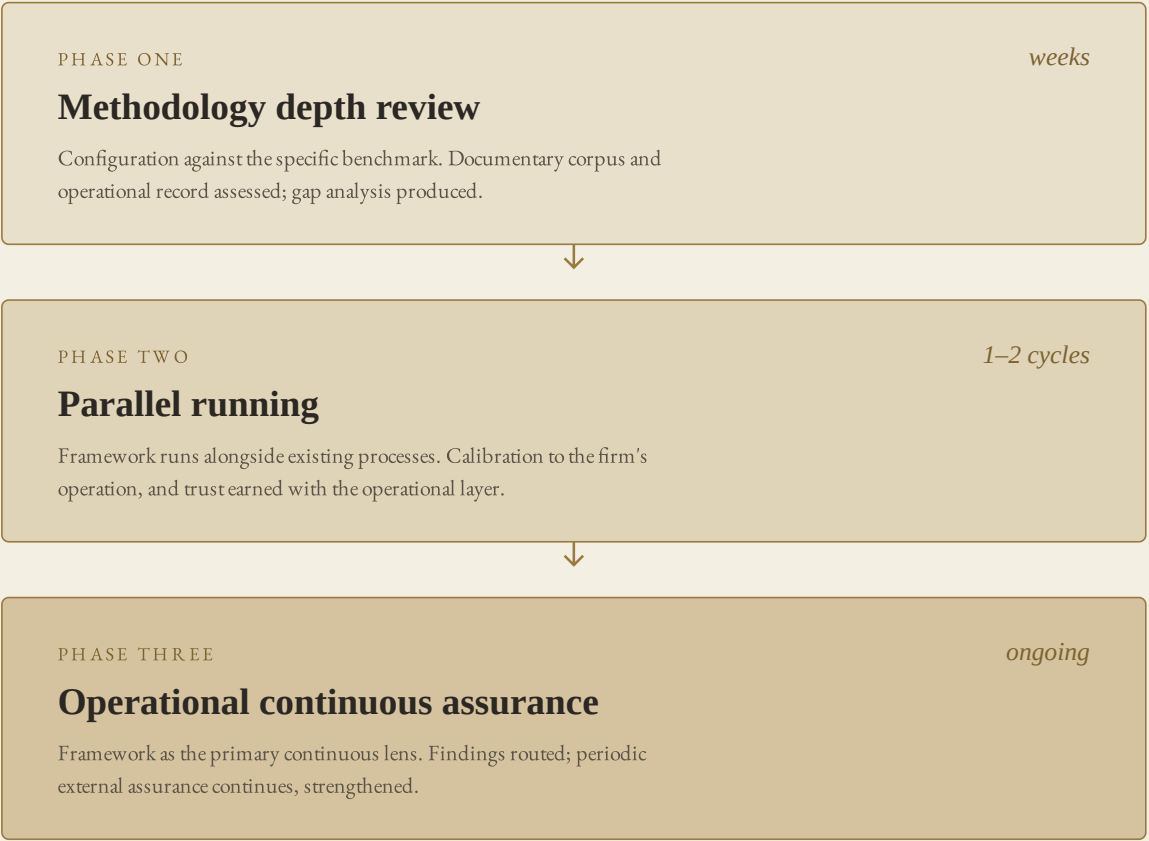
Phase one — methodology depth review. The framework is mapped against the benchmark's methodology, supporting documentation, governance structure and operational practice, producing the configuration that lets it read the operation as the firm's senior analysts read it. The output is itself a deliverable — a structured assessment of the corpus against the regime, preliminary application findings, and a gap analysis of what the firm captures against what continuous assurance requires. A firm completing this phase has a stronger compliance position than it began with, regardless of whether it proceeds.

Phase two — parallel running. The framework runs alongside existing processes for one or two cycles. The gap between what each surfaces is itself a finding. Where the framework catches what the existing process missed, the firm learns what it has been blind to; where the existing process catches what the framework has not yet been configured for, the configuration is sharpened. This phase calibrates the framework and earns the trust of the analyst and editorial teams whose work it reads.

Phase three — operational continuous assurance. The framework runs as the firm's primary continuous lens. Findings route to compliance, to the methodology committee, to the operational layer. Periodic external assurance continues, strengthened by the continuous record and with its footprint shortened over time. The relationship between continuous internal assurance and periodic external assurance becomes additive rather than substitutive.

The framework is the form the engagement takes. The engagement is the work.

Three phases, each a deliverable in itself



Each phase produces a substantive deliverable; the firm's compliance position strengthens at each stage regardless of whether the engagement proceeds to the next.

The thinking is here. The configuration is the work.

The compliance audit cycle for benchmark administrators is built around periodic engagement. This framework is built around continuous engagement, because the integrity of methodological application is itself continuous, and because the patterns that determine a firm's regulatory and commercial standing are visible only across cycles.

It is not a replacement for the compliance function. It is the lens that lets the compliance function see what it is already responsible for. The annual review becomes a checkpoint within a continuous activity rather than the activity itself, and the function moves from preparing once a year for an external review to producing the firm's evidence of methodological integrity continuously — with the structural diagnoses that point at remediation before remediation becomes a regulatory event.

The published price is the product. Its market value rests on the assurance the firm can put behind it. The framework is built for that assurance — against the principles the regime exists to enforce, with the methodology depth required to read the operation competently, and with the structural reasoning required to produce findings that survive the evidence standards a formal assurance opinion holds itself to.

ABOUT

The vantage behind the framework

Karim Bihi writes The Price Reporting Standard, an independent publication on commodity benchmark and regulatory compliance, and works at the intersection of operational compliance practice inside benchmark administrators and the assurance lens that examines those operations from outside.

The work draws on five years of operational compliance experience. Three years inside an IOSCO-aligned commodity PRA — leading the IOSCO assurance programme, designing the oversight committee architecture, and acting as the lead point of contact for the audit of price reporting activity in China conducted under the National Development and Reform Commission in conjunction with the State Administration for Market Regulation. Two years inside the regulated FX market, where the same governance, integrity and methodology questions present in their statutory form. That dual operational vantage runs through the framework set out in this document.

The Price Reporting Standard publishes on a continuous build cadence — analysis, intelligence tracking and operational frameworks added as primary-source work is completed. This framework is the foundation for the operational tools released through the publication, each instantiating a part of the architecture in a form aimed at a specific operational need.

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